

# Seawall height in Surfside

The elevation your city requires, the datum it is measured in, and the section of code that says so.

SURFSIDE · MIAMI-DADE COUNTY

## BFE FEMA base flood elevation, max town DFE

Surfside ties its seawall height to the FEMA flood map, not to a fixed number. Since Ordinance 23-1734 (14 March 2023), the top of a seawall on Biscayne Bay, Indian Creek or Point Lake must be at or above the base flood elevation on the FIRM, may not exceed the town's minimum design flood elevation, and must be built so at least two more feet can be added later. Code Sec. 90-63.4.

### The detail

|                                |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|--------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| MINIMUM                        | At or above the base flood elevation (BFE) on the applicable FEMA Flood Insurance Rate Map, for every seawall fronting Biscayne Bay, Indian Creek and Point Lake. Surfside Code Sec. 90-63.4.                                                                    |
| MAXIMUM                        | No higher than the town's minimum design flood elevation (DFE), which the code puts at approximately plus 8.5 NAVD as of the 2023 ordinance. Sec. 90-63.4(a).                                                                                                    |
| BUILT TO GO HIGHER             | The wall must be structurally designed and built to take at least two feet of additional elevation for projected sea level rise. Sec. 90-63.4(b).                                                                                                                |
| WHEN IT APPLIES                | A new seawall; repairs or renovations costing more than 50% of a new seawall; a new home; or renovations to an existing home exceeding 50% of the home's fair market value. Sec. 90-63.4(c).                                                                     |
| THE HOUSE CAN TRIGGER THE WALL | Building a new home, or renovating one past half its value, brings the seawall under this rule even when nobody planned to touch the wall. Sec. 90-63.4(c)(iii)-(iv).                                                                                            |
| WHERE THE OLD FIGURE CAME FROM | Earlier copy on this site said 5 ft above mean low water. The seawall rule in Sec. 90-63.4 was rewritten by Ord. 23-1734 and now uses the FEMA map; mean low water survives in Sec. 90-63.1 and 90-63.3, which set the shore-end and seaward-end tops of groins. |
| MIND THE DATUM                 | Your BFE is read from the FIRM in the datum the map states, and the DFE cap is given in NAVD. Take both from your survey and the map rather than converting by rule of thumb.                                                                                    |
| NO COUNTY FLOOR                | Miami-Dade sets no countywide elevation, so the town's rule is the one that governs.                                                                                                                                                                             |

**Where this comes from:** Town of Surfside Code of Ordinances Sec. 90-63 (90-63.1, 90-63.3, 90-63.4), as amended by Ord. No. 23-1734, Sec. 2, 3-14-23 (Municode); Miami-Dade County Code Ch. 24

**Verified:** 2026-10. Rules change — check the date above against today.

## Before you call a contractor

### 1 Know your datum

A height means nothing without the datum it is measured from. NAVD88 and MLW are different reference points and the same wall gives different numbers in each. Ask which one any quoted elevation refers to.

### 2 Get the existing elevation surveyed

You cannot tell whether a wall meets the requirement by looking at it. A surveyor shooting the top of the cap settles it in an hour.

### 3 Ask what triggers the requirement

Most cities only apply the minimum to new walls or to substantial repair. What counts as substantial is defined differently in each city, and it is usually a percentage of length or of cost.

### 4 Ask about building higher now

Several cities require a wall built below the final figure to be engineered so it can be raised later. Doing it once is cheaper than doing it twice.